

SUZYBOHANMORETONBAYEVENTS

Travel Radio Australia, and we're very honoured to have Susie Bowen from Moreton Bay Tourism and Events here with us. Susie, welcome to the program. Thanks so much, Geoffrey.

Susie, Moreton Bay, such a beautiful area in Queensland, southeast Queensland, right on the coast, and it's just stunning. Tell us all about it. Firstly, it's a really big region.

So we are, depending on where you're travelling into the city of Moreton Bay, we're the third largest LGA in Australia. So we have a really diverse region. So we've got coastline, which is Redcliffe area.

We've got Bribie Island, which is your islands. And then we have a hinterland area as well, which the base of our hinterland starts at Samford, and then about an hour and a half drive to the top of the hinterland of Moreton Bay to an area called Belfork. So it's really diverse in terms of the offering.

Absolutely huge. And I grew up in Nambour, you know, when I was younger in my teens, and the Moreton Bay area features so hugely in there for boating and people visiting. Moreton Bay itself, tell us a bit about that.

Yeah, so we have a number of boat operators that service the bay, but one of our biggest tour operators departs from Redcliffe, and that's called Brisbane Whale Watching. So they are a seasonal service that operates from June to October, and they operate seven days a week. They pick up from Brisbane City, so particularly great for the international market that are staying in Brisbane City.

Brisbane Whale Watching will come out and pick them up and then depart from Redcliffe. And you're guaranteed to see whales, and it's whale season right now. So the whales are on the northern migration heading up north, and the whale, they go outside of Moreton Island.

And then on the southern migration towards the end of the season, they'll come into the bay. So we've got babies and mummies frolicking in Moreton Bay, just off the coast of Redcliffe. And it is an incredible experience, because they do come right up to the boat and play with the boats, and really an incredible thing to see.

It really is. How we position, and I know how Captain Kerry and her team really promote Brisbane Whale Watching, is you're having lunch with the whales. Because it's a custom boat, so if you're inside sitting down having your lunch, the whales come right up to the boat and you're at eye level.

Or you can be outside and seeing the whales breaching. It's a pretty cool experience. And tell us about the hinterland.

That is a gorgeous area too. It really is. So we have a number of farms.

We have farmstay operators as well. Or if you've got people that want to feel and touch and see animals, we've got a couple of awesome operators called White Ridge Farm or Truvenna Glen Farm. So you can actually get in and pat the animals and brush their coats, and it's a really interactive, cool experience.

Now there's two teams that you have. You have the tourism and events. Tell us about some of the events that happen in the region.

Yeah, so we've got a number of events. So our team at tourism events, Moreton Bay, we deliver 13 signature events, which are community events that we deliver on behalf of our council. They are events like Pride Fest, which is an annual event.

We also run Kite Fest, which is Vietjet Kite Fest, and you see kites in the sky. We also have a marathon, and it's called the United Airlines Jetty to Jetty Marathon. This is the first year that it's the full marathon distance.

It's one of the most scenic runs. It runs along the coastline, and people can run all different race levels from 3K up to the full marathon. But then in terms of other events, there's things like the Abbey Medieval Festival.

So that's in July, and it's incredible. It sells out within hours. So unfortunately, you may have missed this year's, but keep an eye out.

It's always mid-July. And then there's another event, which is an annual event called the Woodford Folk Festival, and that's a music and cultural event. It's very diverse in terms of the events that we have in the city of Moreton Bay, and an event calendar that covers a whole full 12 months.

What about public transport? If people are landing in Brisbane, how can they get to your region via the public transport? Yeah, there is public transport. So we've got train. So the Redcliffe line will take you into Redcliffe, and then there's also the line that goes right up to the Sunshine Coast, and there's buses as well.

In terms of how we position Moreton Bay, it really is a self-drive destination. So get in your car, come out, and go exploring. Four-wheel drive opportunities too, isn't there? Yeah, there definitely is.

Bribie Island, you can get a permit to drive on the beach. But what we've got is an incredible operator called G'day Adventure Tours. So he does four-wheel drive beach tours on the beach, and it is a quintessential tour.

So you will see kangaroos on the beach. You'll see sea eagles. You can go kayaking on Tea

Tree Lakes.

So it's a full Australian experience right on your doorstep on Bribie Island. Moreton Island, such a beautiful region of Australia. And make sure you make a point of going to see it because it's so great.

What about your background, Susie? How did you come to be in this role? I have been in the tourism industry my whole career. I love it. I started out in airlines.

I've been very fortunate to work across multiple sectors in the industry. So I've worked for airlines. I've worked in hotels.

But I've been in destination marketing for the last kind of probably six years now, and I absolutely love it. But what I love most, obviously, I've remade it Tourism Events, Moreton Bay is Destination Marketing. Our other remit is Industry Development and Capability Building, which I am very passionate about.

So what I love about my role now in the tourism industry is the support that we can give to operators to help them to showcase their business and to help distribute them through the different plethora of trade distribution and ways to market their business. So I'm really passionate about that. We are here at Arrival 360 in Brisbane.

Tell us your opinions about this particular conference. It's great. First time in Australia.

So to be honest, I didn't know what to expect. But it's been really worthwhile. Just to have a dedicated experiences conference has been excellent.

So it's really touched on the things that can help operators to distribute their business and just to understand the trends that are coming, particularly in that AI space, and really trying to unpack what that means for an operator to apply to their business. So I've taken so many notes that I'll be taking back to Moreton Bay to share with our operators. So yeah, it's been really good.

Susie Bowen from Moreton Bay Tourism and Events. How can people find out more online about the region? If you go to visitmoretonbay.com.au, just have a look there and we have all of the information you'll need about Moreton Bay and beyond. Thanks so much for being part of Travel Radio Australia.

Thanks so much for the opportunity. Cheers.